GODDESS OF VOODOO

Trigger Condition: Marcus tells Harlan about Marie's powers **Night:** Night 18 **Branches:** Two — *Companion* and *Pet* **Prerequisite:** MARIE_FORMALLY_MET + HARLAN_TOLD_ABOUT_MARIE set

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THE REVELATION — What Harlan Was Actually Doing

When Marcus tells Harlan about Marie — her practice, what she did to Ricky, the lock opening in the cellar, the swamp moving at her command, the symbols on her walls matching the boundary markers — Harlan's face does something it has never done in any prior interaction.

It goes unguarded.

Not afraid. Not surprised exactly. The expression of a man who has been searching for a specific frequency for a very long time and has just heard it clearly for the first time.

He stands up. He was sitting. He stands up in one motion.

"Describe it again," he says. *"Exactly."*

Marcus describes it again.

Harlan is already moving. He goes to the old canvas bag he keeps near the field's edge — the one Marcus has seen before but never seen opened. He unzips it. Inside: equipment that does not belong to 1960. Instruments with no analog in the current world. A communication device of some kind — compact, precise, nothing like a radio.

"I need to make a call," he says.

He looks at Marcus with the closest thing to apology his face has ever produced.

"The werewolves were a secondary concern," he says. *"A significant one — but secondary."* He picks up the device. *"We detected energy signatures from this location eighteen months ago. Old signatures. Older than anything we've documented in a living source."*

He looks north toward the swamp.

"I was sent to find the source."

A beat.

"I found it."

He makes his call. Marcus can hear one side of it — clipped, precise, using terminology that means nothing in 1960 rural America. Grid coordinates. Threat classification. A phrase that comes through clearly: *confirmed old god trace, living host, recommend immediate extraction team.*

He ends the call. Looks at Marcus.

"Go inside," he says. *"Stay inside tonight."*

HARLAN_TOLD_ABOUT_MARIE set GODDESS_THREAD_ACTIVE set DOMINION_EXTRACTION_INCOMING set

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NIGHT 18 — THE SHIPS COME

IF MARCUS IS ASLEEP — WOKEN UP

Something pulls him out of sleep that isn't sound and isn't light. It is a feeling — the specific feeling of a name being called in a frequency below hearing. Not his name. Something underneath his name. The wolf hears it before he does.

He is sitting up in bed before he knows why.

Then he hears it — a sound like wind that isn't wind, a displacement of air that has direction and purpose. Through the window: lights moving over the swamp. Not lanterns. Not anything that belongs to 1960. Hovering shapes, dark against the darker sky, moving in formation over the tree line above Marie's territory.

Then — from the swamp — gunfire. And under it, between the shots, something that is not gunfire. Something older and wetter and wrong.

And then: the pull.

IF MARCUS IS AWAKE — He SEES IT FIRST

The shapes come in from the south, low and fast, running dark until they're over the swamp and then searchlights drop. Advanced craft — nothing in this era has the silhouette. They hover. Dominion cleaners rappel down on lines into the willow canopy below.

For thirty seconds the swamp is quiet.

Then it isn't.

The first explosion of sound — gunfire from the cleaners, disciplined, coordinated. Then something answers it that has no name in any weapons catalog. The swamp *moves.* The lights on two of the craft swing violently sideways as something below them shifts. A cleaner on a rappel line goes silent mid-descent.

And then Marcus feels it.

THE PULL — Both Paths Converge

It starts in his chest and radiates outward — not pain, not hunger, not rage. Something else entirely. Something that bypasses every system of resistance Marcus has built over eighteen days and goes straight to whatever the wolf is built on top of.

Marie.

Not her voice. Her *presence.* Pulling. Deliberate. Directional.

Come.

MOVING THROUGH TOWN

Marcus goes. He doesn't decide to go — or he decides and his body was already moving. Either way he is out the door and on the road before anyone in town has processed what the lights in the sky are.

Dominion agents are in the street. They see Marcus. They move to intercept.

He is faster than they expect. He is faster than he expected. The abilities that have been building for eighteen days — the instinct, the speed, the strength — consolidate into something seamless. He doesn't fight through them. He moves *around* them, past them, through gaps they don't realize they've left.

One agent grabs his arm. Marcus looks at him.

The agent lets go.

FEAR_PRESENCE at full force without effort. Marcus doesn't notice. He is already gone.

The swamp path opens in front of him like it was waiting.

THE SWAMP — Carnage

The path through Marie's territory has always felt like entering something deliberate. Tonight it feels like entering a battlefield.

Bodies. Dominion cleaners — professional, equipped, trained for things civilians don't survive — scattered across the swamp path and the water's edge and the willow roots in various states of having been stopped. Vines that don't grow this thick wrapped around armored limbs like they've been there for years. One cleaner suspended ten feet up in the willow canopy, held there by roots through his tactical vest, perfectly preserved and perfectly still.

The swamp is breathing. Marcus can feel it — the land itself, the threshold, the ancient thing underneath Wroughtwood that has been sleeping since the markers came down, stirring. It recognizes what is walking through it.

The path is clear. Specifically, deliberately clear — a corridor through the carnage pointing directly ahead. Marie made this path for Marcus. She knew he was coming before he left the inn.

He follows it deeper.

MARIE — THE CLEARING

She is in the clearing where she first tested him — where the pack scout came and Pack Sense unlocked. The fire is out. The cabin behind her is dark.

She is on one knee.

Her arm — the one that was healing, the claw marks from the pack — is opened again. Something dark moves at the wound's edge. She has been hit by something Dominion brought that she didn't account for. Her breathing is controlled and deliberate, the breathing of someone managing pain through force of will.

The swamp around her is still. The willows hang motionless. Even the water has stopped.

Two cleaners stand before her.

They are not like the others on the path. Their armor is different — layered, dark, with components that glow at the joints with a light that has no color name. Eldritch-powered power armor. They move with the weight of machinery but the precision of something guided by intelligence. In each gauntlet — weapons that Marcus cannot categorize, pointed at Marie.

Marie looks up. Her eyes find Marcus across the clearing.

She reaches out her hand.

THE CHOICE

Harlan's voice behind Marcus:

"Don't."

He is there. Of course he is there. He has been following since the inn. His breath is slightly elevated — he ran — but his voice is steady. In his right hand: a revolver. Large caliber. The cylinder loaded with rounds that catch the clearing's faint light in a specific way.

Silver.

"Marcus." His voice is careful. Professional. The voice he uses when he needs someone to understand something quickly. *"I know what she is to you. I know what these weeks have been."* He takes one step forward. *"She is not what you think she is. She is older than this land. Older than anything in those woods. She is dangerous in ways that make everything else we've discussed look manageable."*

Marie's hand is still extended. Her eyes on Marcus. Her expression — for the first time, in all their interactions — is open. Not diagnostic, not calculating, not the careful revelation of controlled information.

Asking.

"Stand down," Harlan says. *"Let the cleaners do their job. We can contain her. Study her. It doesn't have to end—"*

"Marcus," Marie says.

Just his name. In that voice. With that accent. With eighteen days of everything underneath it.

BRANCH A — INTERVENE: *Companion*

Condition: HUMANITY > 40 at point of choice

Marcus moves.

THE FIGHT

He crosses the clearing in three strides and hits the nearest cleaner at the shoulder — not the wolf, not a blackout, a deliberate controlled collision with every ounce of enhanced strength eighteen days of infection has built into his body.

The cleaner is larger than Marcus. The armor is reinforced. Marcus hits it anyway and they go down together and the weapon in its gauntlet discharges into the canopy above them rather than into Marie.

FROM BEHIND — the crack of Harlan's revolver.

A silver round. Large caliber. Moving at a speed that means Marcus should not have been able to perceive it as anything other than sound and impact.

He perceived it.

He felt it coming — Pack Sense, Heightened Reflexes, something that might be Marie pulling the air slightly to the left — and he was already moving, already rolling, and the round passes close enough to his temple that he feels the heat of it.

It strikes the second cleaner in the back of the neck between the armor plates.

The cleaner goes down.

Harlan stares at what just happened. He fired to stop Marcus. He hit the cleaner. He doesn't understand yet why those two things are the same outcome.

Marcus is on the first cleaner. The armor is strong. Marcus is something that has been building for eighteen days toward exactly this. He gets a gauntlet off. Gets the weapon. Pins the arm. The cleaner is neutralized — contained, not killed, Marcus's choice, Marcus's control.

He stands up.

Behind him — the sound of roots.

The second cleaner — Harlan's silver round in its neck, down but not finished, raising its weapon toward Marie one last time — is taken by the swamp. Vines from the water's edge, from the willow roots, from the ground itself move in a single coordinated motion. They wrap. They crush.

A sound.

Then quiet.

Marie is on her feet. Her arm is still bleeding. She looks at the clearing — at the cleaners, at the state of things — with the expression of someone doing a final count.

Then she looks at Marcus.

Something in her face that she has never shown in eighteen days of careful controlled interaction.

Undone. Just briefly. Just for a second. A woman who has been alone for longer than Marcus can comprehend, looking at someone who chose her.

She crosses to him. She takes his face in both hands — her hands are warm, warmer than the fire ever accounted for — and she looks at him the way she looked through him on the first night. Except this time she isn't looking through. She is looking *at.*

"Bon," she says softly. *"Bon."*

HARLAN — THE PLEA

He is still standing at the clearing's edge. The revolver at his side. He looks at the cleaners. At the swamp. At Marie and Marcus.

"You don't understand what you're doing," he says. His voice has lost the professional steadiness. Underneath it something human and tired. *"What she is — what you are becoming — there are protocols for this. There are reasons for the protocols."*

He takes a step forward.

"You'll be hunted. Both of you. Dominion doesn't stop. They'll send more cleaners. They'll send people I can't warn you about because I don't know who they are." His voice drops. *"I'm trying to tell you that the world outside this swamp is not going to let this exist. I am trying to—"*

Marie moves.

She doesn't rush. She doesn't raise her voice. She walks past Marcus toward Harlan with the unhurried certainty of someone who has already made this calculation and is simply completing it. Her hand extends.

Harlan raises the revolver.

She touches the barrel. Just the barrel. The revolver folds — the metal bends like warm wax, slowly, deliberately, until it is no longer a weapon and Harlan is holding a sculpture.

She looks at him for a moment.

"You were never going to stop," she says. Gently. Like explaining something to someone who couldn't help being what they were. *"That's not a criticism. That's just true."*

She closes her hand.

What happens to Harlan is not violent in a way that involves blood or sound. He simply stops. A man who has been doing a job for longer than Marcus has been alive, stopping.

He had a file on Marie. He had eighteen months of sensor readings. He had a thorough report already transmitted.

None of it was enough.

THE ENDING — Companion

The swamp settles. The hovering craft above — two remaining, having lost contact with their ground teams — hang in the air for a long moment. Then they pull back. Someone above made a calculation about acceptable losses.

Marie and Marcus stand in the clearing.

She is already healing. The wound on her arm closing faster now, the dark thing at its edges retreating. She looks at the sky until the craft are gone. Then she looks at the swamp — her swamp, her land, the threshold that has been hers since before this land had a name.

"They will come back," she says.

"I know."

"We will not be here when they do."

She looks at Marcus. She picks up the compass from where it fell — Jacob's compass, which has been in his pocket since the north road, which has been pointing at things Marcus needed to find. She turns it over in her hands. The needle spins once and settles.

Pointing south. Away from Wroughtwood. Away from Cord and the pack and Darnell and everything Marcus walked into on that road.

She holds it out.

Marcus takes it.

They walk south together out of the swamp and out of Wroughtwood and into whatever the world becomes when you stop being what you were and haven't decided yet what you're going to be instead.

Fade to black.

In 1963, Dominion field offices in four southern states log simultaneous incidents of unexplained origin. The signature matches no known classification. Agents sent to investigate do not return.

The file remains open.

ENDING: GODDESS OF VOODOO *She was never the supporting character. She was always the story. You just had to choose to be part of it.*

BRANCH B — STAND DOWN: *Pet*

Condition: HUMANITY below 40 OR player hesitates / chooses not to intervene

Marcus stops.

It is not cowardice exactly. It is the accumulated weight of eighteen days of being told what is dangerous, what is sensible, what a man in his position should and shouldn't do. It is Harlan's voice, steady and professional behind him. It is the armor on those cleaners and the weapons in their gauntlets and the ships above the canopy.

It is the part of Marcus that is still trying to be reasonable in a situation that stopped being reasonable on Day 1.

He stops.

Marie's extended hand stays in the air for one more second.

Then it drops.

WHAT HAPPENS TO THE CLEANERS

The clearing changes temperature.

Not colder. *Older.* Like the air itself has remembered something it forgot it knew. The light from the cleaners' armor joints flickers — not from damage, from interference. Something in the frequency of the world in this clearing is no longer compatible with the frequency of their equipment.

Marie stands up.

She is not on one knee anymore. She is not wounded anymore. The mark on her arm is gone — not healed, *gone*, as if it decided it had never been there. She is standing in the center of the clearing and she is—

She is what she actually is.

Not the woman at the fire. Not the careful practitioner with the measured voice and the deliberate reveals. The thing that was on this land before the tribe, before the soldiers, before the markers, before any of it. The thing that watched all of it happen and chose to wear a human face because it was convenient and occasionally interesting.

The cleaners raise their weapons.

The weapons stop working.

The cleaners — Dominion trained, eldritch-powered, prepared for things that would end a normal person — look at what is standing in the clearing and their training fails them in the specific way that training fails when it encounters something that the training was not built to address.

What happens to them is red and immediate and complete.

The swamp absorbs it. The way the swamp absorbs everything.

MARIE TURNS TO MARCUS

The clearing is quiet. The ships above are pulling back — their instruments have gone dark, their communications cut, something has reached up through the canopy and into their systems.

Marie looks at Marcus.

She has worn many expressions in eighteen days. This one is new. It is not anger. Anger implies surprise and she is never surprised. It is not betrayal — betrayal implies she expected better and she made no such error.

It is the expression of a reclassification. Marcus was one thing. He is now another thing.

"I see," she says.

Her voice is the same. Unhurried. Accented. It is somehow the most frightening thing in the clearing.

She walks toward him. He should run. The wolf knows he should run — it is suddenly very clear to the wolf that this is not a thing to run toward. He cannot move.

She takes his face in her hands — the same gesture, the same warmth — and she looks at him the way she looked at him on the first night.

"You are not ready to be a companion," she says. *"That's alright."*

Her thumbs press gently against his temples.

"You can be something else."

THE TRANSFORMATION

HUMANITY drops to zero.

Not gradually. Not the slow erosion of eighteen days of choices. All at once — like a cord cut. The number hits the floor and the game does not cut to black.

Marcus transforms. Fully. Completely. For the first time in the entire game the wolf comes out not in a blackout, not in a partial surge, but in total daylight with Marcus watching it happen and unable to stop it.

It does not hurt. That is the worst part. He thought it would hurt.

The clearing is very large when he is finished. Or he is very low to the ground. The smells are overwhelming — every person who has ever been in this swamp, every animal, every plant, every history of the land compressed into immediate present-tense information.

Marie is in front of him.

She looks the same from down here. She looks the same from anywhere. She crouches to his level and looks at him with those eyes that give back more than they receive.

"There," she says.

She puts her hand on his head. He does not pull away.

"You'll learn," she says. *"They always learn."*

HARLAN

Harlan has been standing at the clearing's edge through all of it. He watched Marcus stop. He watched what Marie did to the cleaners. He watched the transformation. He is holding the ruined revolver — she bent it, even now, even in this branch, she bent it without looking at him because she did not need to look at him.

He is a man whose entire professional framework has just been stress-tested beyond its rated capacity.

He takes one step forward. He wants to say something. He has been Dominion for thirty years. He has a response for most situations.

Marie looks at him over her shoulder. Just looks.

Harlan stops.

The thing that was Marcus looks at Harlan too. It knows who Harlan is. Some of it still knows who Harlan is.

"He was trying to help you," Marie says to Marcus — to the wolf. Conversational. As if the wolf can follow it.

The wolf can follow it.

"I know," she says. *"That's why I'm going to let him leave."*

She looks at Harlan. Her expression is not cruel. It is more dispassionate than cruelty — the expression of someone making a practical decision.

"Go," she says. *"File your report. Tell them what you found."* A pause. *"Tell them what it cost."*

Harlan looks at the wolf. At Marie. At the swamp and the carnage and the ships retreating above the canopy.

He leaves.

He files his report.

The report is classified at the highest level. A notation is added: *Source considered compromised. Full quarantine recommended. Do not re-engage without authorization from Director level.*

Nobody re-engages.

THE ENDING — Pet

The swamp is quiet.

Marie and the wolf that was Marcus Grave move through the willow curtain toward the water's edge. She walks. He moves beside her — not behind, not leashed, not chained. Beside. The way a thing that has been claimed moves with the thing that claimed it.

She puts her hand on his back as they walk.

"You'll remember most of it," she says. *"For a while."*

She looks at the water.

"The ones before you remembered for years. One of them — a very long time ago — remembered for decades." She almost sounds sorry. *"It fades. It always fades."*

The wolf that was Marcus Grave makes no sound.

The willows close behind them.

In 1963, Dominion field offices in four southern states log simultaneous incidents of unexplained origin — the same signature as the Wroughtwood file. Two agents sent to investigate the first incident do not return. The second incident is logged and closed without investigation.

Harold Doss retires in 1964. He does not discuss the Wroughtwood assignment.

The file on Marie Veau remains open. It always will.

Fade to black.

ENDING: GODDESS OF VOODOO *She offered you a hand. You had to decide what kind of man you were. You found out.*

ENDING COMPARISON

	Companion	**Pet**
Marcus	Walks out with Marie as equal	Transforms completely, kept
Marie	Chooses Marcus because he chose her	Keeps Marcus because something must be kept
Harlan	Killed by Marie	Released by Marie — and that's worse
The World	Hunted but free	Safe but gone
Humanity	Held	Lost
The Compass	Given back — pointing south	Left in the swamp
Final Note	*She was always the story*	*You found out*

FLAGS REQUIRED

Flag	**Branch**
HARLAN_TOLD_ABOUT_MARIE	Both — trigger condition
GODDESS_THREAD_ACTIVE	Both
MARIE_FORMALLY_MET	Both
HUMANITY > 40	Companion branch
HUMANITY ≤ 40	Pet branch (or player hesitates)
JACOB_COMPASS_FOUND	Companion — compass returned in ending